

The Five Points of Arminianism Contrasted with the Five Points of Calvinism

Taken from *The Five Points of Calvinism* by David N. Steele and Curtis C. Thomas.
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THE "FIVE POINTS" OF ARMINIANISM

1. *Free Will or Human Ability*

Although human nature was seriously affected by the fall, man has not been left in a state of total spiritual helplessness. God graciously enables every sinner to repent and believe, but He does so in such a manner as not to interfere with man's freedom. Each sinner possesses a free will, and his eternal destiny depends on how he uses it. Man's freedom consists of his ability to choose good over evil in spiritual matters; his will is not enslaved to his sinful nature. The sinner has the power to either cooperate with God's Spirit and be regenerated or resist God's grace and perish. The lost sinner needs the Spirit's assistance, but he does not have to be regenerated by the Spirit before he can believe, for faith is man's act and precedes the new birth. Faith is the sinner's gift to God; it is man's contribution to salvation.

THE "FIVE POINTS" OF CALVINISM

1. *Total Inability or Depravity*

Because of the fall, man is unable of himself to savingly believe the gospel. The sinner is dead, blind, and deaf to the things of God; his heart is deceitful and desperately corrupt. His will is not free; it is in bondage to his evil nature, therefore he will not—indeed he cannot—choose good over evil in the spiritual realm. Consequently, it takes much more than the Spirit's assistance to bring a sinner to Christ: it takes regeneration by which the Spirit makes the sinner alive and gives him a new nature. Faith is not something man contributes to salvation but is itself a part of God's gift of salvation—it is God's gift to the sinner, not the sinner's gift to God.

2. Conditional Election

God's choice of certain individuals unto salvation before the foundation of the world was based on His foreseeing that they would respond to His call. He selected only those whom He knew would of themselves freely believe the gospel. Election therefore was determined by—or conditioned upon—what man would do. The faith God foresaw was not given to the sinner by God but resulted solely from man's will. Thus the sinner's choice of Christ, not God's choice of the sinner, is the ultimate cause of salvation.

3. Universal Redemption or General Atonement

Christ's redeeming work made it possible for everyone to be saved but did not actually secure the salvation of anyone. Christ's redemption becomes effective only if man chooses to accept it.

2. Unconditional Election

God's choice of certain individuals unto salvation before the foundation of the world rested solely in His sovereign will. His choice was not based on any foreseen response such as faith or repentance. On the contrary, God gives faith and repentance to each individual He chooses. Election was not determined by any act foreseen in man. Those whom God sovereignly elected He brings, by the Spirit's power, to a willing acceptance of Christ. Thus God's choice of the sinner, not the sinner's choice of Christ, is the ultimate cause of salvation.

3. Particular Redemption or Limited Atonement

Christ's redeeming work was intended to save the elect only and actually secured salvation for them. His death was a substitutionary endurance of the penalty of sin in the place of certain specified sinners.

4. The Holy Spirit Can Be Effectually Resisted

The Spirit calls inwardly all who are outwardly called by the gospel; but because man is free, he can resist the Spirit's call. God's grace is not invincible; it can be resisted.

4. Irresistible Grace

Along with the outward call of the gospel, the Spirit extends to the elect a special inward call that inevitably brings them to salvation. God's grace is invincible; it never fails.

5. Falling from Grace

Those who are truly saved may lose their salvation by turning from the faith.

5. Perseverance of the Saints

All who are chosen by God, redeemed by Christ, and given faith by the Spirit will persevere to the end. They are kept by God's power.

According to Arminianism:

Salvation involves the combined efforts of *God* (who takes the initiative) and *man* (whose response is decisive).

According to Calvinism:

Salvation is accomplished by the almighty power of the Triune God—election, redemption, and regeneration are the work of God alone, and are entirely by grace.

